Europe as the Catholic Church's authority began to be challenged. It was also a time of extraordinary scientific advances, which some saw as the beginnings of a "scientific revolution." Discoveries in astronomy, physics, and medicine gave rise to the idea that science could tell humans everything about the universe, and that knowledge would make humans its masters. Many scientists of the era believed that humans had a privileged place in a universe created by God for humanity to inhabit. English philosopher and scientist Francis Bacon, a pioneer in the development of scientific method, reinforced this idea; the natural world, in his view, existed to provide for humans, and should be conquered and exploited.

Bacon's view later became known as "Imperial Ecology"—the idea that humanity's knowledge of science and technology should be used to gain dominance over the natural world. Imperial ecology became the predominant ideology throughout the European Renaissance, Enlightenment—an 18th century movement dedicated to the pursuit of knowledge—and later Industrial Revolution of the 18th and 19th centuries.